

BOMBERS ON DECK

Sixteen North American B-25 Mitchell bombers are parked nose to tail on the deck of USS Hornet, on their way across the Pacific for the April 1942 Doolittle bombing raid on Tokyo. The B-25s were too large to be stowed below decks.

to within striking distance of Hawaii, refueling from tankers in heavy seas.

While the Japanese were greatly aided by the peace-numbed laxness of American defenses, their pilots carried through the two-wave attack with skill and determination. They had the best naval aircraft in the world at that time, in the Mitsubishi A6M Reisen (Zero) fighter and the Nakajima Kate attack aircraft, used as both a torpedo-bomber and a conventional horizontal bomber. The other type used in the Pearl Harbor operation, the Aichi Val dive-bomber, was broadly similar in its strengths and weaknesses to the German Stuka.

The practical impact of the Japanese action was limited by the absence of US carriers from Pearl Harbor on that day and by their failure to destroy oil tanks, which allowed a faster American recovery than might otherwise have been the case.

**AMERICAN VENGEANCE**

The "sneak" attack on Pearl Harbor created a desire for instant revenge that was partially satisfied by the air raid on Tokyo in 1942.

Still, 18 ships were sunk or seriously damaged and some 164 aircraft destroyed on the ground, for the loss of only 29 Japanese aircraft out of a strike force of 353 planes.

Pearl Harbor convinced most remaining doubters of the power of carrier-borne aircraft as the decisive strike-force in naval warfare. Also, the destruction or temporary disablement of so much of the United States' surface fleet left the carriers as the US Navy's key warships in the Pacific. The carriers' intended role had originally been a subordinate one, as providers of air support for the fleet. Now they would steal center stage, with the chief function of the surface warships becoming to provide a protective screen for the carriers.

